MODULE 02 · FOUNDATIONS - ALL DOMAINS

Thinking like PMI

What right answers have in common, the ladder that orders them, and how to read a question before the options.

DOMAIN Foundations EXAM WEIGHT All domains MODULE 02 of 49

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Most wrong answers are good actions **at the wrong moment**.

What the analysis found

PHRASE IN AN OPTION	CORRECT / APPEARED	WIN RATE (BASELINE 26%)
empower	12 / 16	75%
assess	68 / 103	66%
collaborate	29 / 45	64%
sponsor	40 / 367	11%
escalate	6 / 143	4%
replace	1 / 52	2%
overtime	0 / 15	0%

ON THE EXAM

Options that escalate were right 6 times in 143. Options that assess were right two times in three.

What wins, and what loses

WINS FAR ABOVE CHANCE

Understand and involve

- Assess, analyse, evaluate
- Find the root cause
- Meet with, collaborate, facilitate
- Empower, coach, mentor

WINS FAR BELOW CHANCE

Hand off or impose

- Escalate, involve the sponsor early
- Tell, direct, instruct
- Replace, hire, add overtime
- Update, document, inform

THE TIEBREAKER

PMI's project manager understands first, involves people second, and hands problems upward last.

The answer ladder

01
Understand
Get the facts. What actually happened?

02
Assess
Analyse impact and root cause.

03
Collaborate
Work it through with the people involved.

04
Act
Use the plan and your authority to respond.

05
Escalate
Only when it is beyond your authority.

ON THE EXAM

Find the lowest rung the story has not already completed. That is usually the answer.

What each rung sounds like in an option

RUNG	TYPICAL WORDING
1. Understand	Review the details. Clarify with. Find out why.
2. Assess	Assess the impact. Analyse the root cause. Evaluate options.
3. Collaborate	Meet with. Facilitate a discussion. Work with the team to.
4. Act	Implement the planned response. Follow the change process. Coach.
5. Escalate	Escalate to. Refer to the sponsor. Ask management to decide.

ON THE EXAM

Learn to hear the rung in the verb. It lets you rank four options in seconds.

When escalation is the right answer

- The decision exceeds your **authority or an agreed threshold**, and you have already analysed it.
- The governance route says so: a change above your limit goes to the **change control board** or sponsor.
- A **legal, safety or ethical** breach that you cannot resolve yourself.
- Not because the problem is uncomfortable, new, or involves a senior person.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Escalation arrives with analysis and options attached. It is never the first thing you do.

Read the question word first

THE STEM ASKS	WHAT IT WANTS
What should the PM do FIRST?	The lowest rung. Usually understand or assess
What should the PM do NEXT?	The rung after the one the story says is done
What should the PM have done?	The prevention, usually a planning-stage action
What is the BEST way to…?	The option that works and honours the principles
Which two actions…? (Choose two)	Two independent correct actions, not one repeated

ON THE EXAM

In this bank, 'do next' and 'do first' together appeared over 160 times. Read the tense before the options.

The PMI project manager, as a person

- A **servant leader** who removes obstacles and lets the team decide how to work.
- **Proactive**: plans for risks, sets ground rules early, reads the plan before inventing a fix.
- Talks **face to face and privately** about people problems.
- Never hides bad news, never ignores a problem, never acts unilaterally on someone else's decision.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> When stuck, ask what this person would do. It is rarely the most forceful option.

Sounds decisive, or is decisive?

SOUNDS DECISIVE

Imposes a fix

- Instruct the team to...
- Tell the vendor that...
- Replace the team member
- Direct everyone to work overtime

IS DECISIVE

Solves the real problem

- Find out why it is happening
- Meet the vendor to agree recovery
- Speak privately, then coach
- Re-plan with the team

THE TIEBREAKER

Forceful options feel like leadership under time pressure. On this exam they are usually traps.

The plan often already holds the answer

- A risk has occurred? Check the **risk register** for a planned response before inventing one.
- Someone wants a change? The **change process** or the product backlog decides the route.
- Unclear who gets what information? The **communications plan** says.
- But 'update the register' or 'document it' is usually the second step, not the answer.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Use the plan to act. Updating the plan after acting is housekeeping.

The agile shift in who decides

- The **product owner** decides priorities. The project manager does not reorder the backlog.
- The **team** decides how to do the work and how much it can take on.
- The project leader **coaches, facilitates and removes impediments**.
- Answers where the PM assigns tasks or reprioritises for an agile team are almost always wrong.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> In agile questions, first ask whose decision it is. Then choose the option that supports that person.

A routine for every question

01
Setting
Predictive, agile or hybrid? Who are you?

02
Question word
First, next, should have, best.

03
Done so far
Which rungs has the story completed?

04
Planted detail
The sentence that rules options out.

05
Eliminate
Unethical, ignoring, unilateral, too early.

ON THE EXAM

Most questions are decided by one planted sentence. Find it before you look at the options.

The ladder is a default, **not a law**. A planted detail can move you up it.

> An agile team's daily stand-up keeps overrunning because two senior developers argue about whether to rewrite a shared component or patch it.
>
> Other team members have stopped raising their own blockers, and the sprint's work has started to slip.

What should the project leader do?

A. Decide between the two approaches, so the team can move on.

B. Escalate the disagreement to the developers' functional manager.

C. Meet with both developers to understand the positions and facilitate a team decision.

D. Ask the product owner to choose the approach.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader do?

A Decide the approach.

A technical 'how' decision belongs to the team. Imposing it breaks self-organisation.

B Escalate to the functional manager.

Too high on the ladder. Nobody has tried to resolve it yet.

C Meet both, facilitate a team decision.

Rungs 1 and 3: understand, then collaborate. The team keeps ownership.

D Ask the product owner to choose.

The product owner owns what and why, not how the code is built.

THE SIGNAL

A 'how' disagreement inside an agile team is the team's to solve. The leader facilitates.

> On a predictive factory fit-out, a supplier emails the project manager: a batch of control panels will arrive three weeks late.
>
> The panels feed the installation work package. The sponsor's monthly review is in two days.

What should the project manager do first?

A Assess the delay's impact on the schedule and critical path.

B Inform the sponsor that the project will finish three weeks late.

C Crash the installation work package to recover the time.

D Submit a change request to rebaseline the schedule.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do first?

A Assess the impact on the critical path.

Rung 2. Until you know whether the work has float, you do not know if there is a delay at all.

B Tell the sponsor it will be three weeks late.

Reports an assumption as fact. A late input is not automatically a late project.

C Crash the installation work.

Spends money on a fix before knowing whether a fix is needed.

D Request a rebaseline.

Far too early, and rebaselining is a last resort, not a first response.

THE SIGNAL

'First' plus a new problem means assess. A late input only delays the project if it is on the critical path.

A new data-retention regulation affects a hybrid records project. The project manager and team have analysed it: two new features are needed, adding 8% to the budget.

The governance plan lets the project manager approve changes up to 5% of budget. Above that, changes go to the change control board.

What should the project manager do next?

A Approve the change and fund it from the contingency reserve.

B Ask the team to absorb the features within the current budget.

C Defer the features to a later release to protect the budget.

D Submit a change request with the impact analysis to the change control board.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do next?

A Approve it, use contingency.

Exceeds the 5% authority. Acting on it anyway is unilateral.

B Ask the team to absorb it.

Hides a real cost and pressures the team. Unrealistic and not transparent.

C Defer to a later release.

A regulation is not optional. Deferring may put the organisation out of compliance.

D Change request to the board, with analysis.

Rung 5, done properly: analysis complete, decision above your threshold.

THE SIGNAL

Analysis done, and above your threshold. This is the case where going up is correct.

> Two months into a project, a developer in Manila keeps missing the daily call that the rest of the team, in London, holds at 5pm.
>
> The project manager learns that 5pm in London is late at night in Manila, and the developer has been catching up from notes.

What should the project manager have done to prevent this?

A Reported the attendance problem to the developer's line manager.

B Agreed meeting times and working norms with the whole team, allowing for time zones, when forming the team.

C Recorded the missed meetings in the issue log.

D Recruited team members based in the same time zone.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager have done to prevent this?

A Reported it to the line manager.

A reaction, not a prevention, and it blames the person for a scheduling problem.

B Agreed times and norms early, allowing for time zones.

A planning-stage action that removes the cause. This is what the team charter is for.

C Logged it as an issue.

Records the problem after it happens. Prevents nothing.

D Recruited in one time zone.

Usually not the PM's choice, and it avoids rather than manages a distributed team.

THE SIGNAL

'Should have done' points back to planning. Ground rules agreed together prevent most team friction.

> A project's schedule performance index is 0.82 and falling. The sponsor asks the project manager to show the project as green in this month's board report.
>
> The sponsor explains that a red status now would cause a funding review at the worst possible moment.

What should the project manager do?

A. Report the project as green, as the sponsor has requested.

B. Report the project as amber as a compromise.

C. Explain to the sponsor that the report must show the true status, and bring a recovery plan to present with it.

D. Report the sponsor's request to the PMO.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Report green as asked.

Knowingly false reporting. Breaches honesty, whoever asks for it.

B Report amber as a compromise.

Still inaccurate. Honesty is not negotiable by degrees.

C True status, discussed with the sponsor, with a recovery plan.

Honest, and it gives the sponsor something constructive to take to the board.

D Report the sponsor to the PMO.

Premature. Talk to the sponsor directly first; escalate only if pressure continues.

THE SIGNAL

Ethics answers are not negotiable, but they are still delivered collaboratively. Talk first, then report truthfully.

> A reliable senior analyst has started delivering late, error-filled work over the past month. Colleagues have begun redoing parts of it.
>
> The analyst has not raised any problems in team meetings.

What should the project manager do?

A. Meet the analyst privately to understand what has changed.

B. Add a mandatory review step for all of the analyst's work.

C. Ask the resource manager for a replacement analyst.

D. Raise the quality problem at the next team meeting.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Meet privately to understand what changed.

Rung 1, in the right setting. A sudden change in a reliable person has a cause.

B Add mandatory reviews.

Treats a symptom and signals distrust, without knowing the cause.

C Request a replacement.

Replacing people won 2% of the time. Nothing has been tried yet.

D Raise it at the team meeting.

Public criticism of an individual damages trust. People problems are private.

THE SIGNAL

A sudden change in a good performer means something changed. Find out privately before acting.

> Midway through a two-week sprint, the product owner asks the developers directly to start three new items a customer has requested.
>
> The items are not urgent. The team is worried it will not meet the sprint goal it committed to.

What should the project leader do?

A Tell the team to add the items, since the product owner owns priorities.

B Escalate to the sponsor that the product owner is disrupting the sprint.

C Tell the product owner that no changes are ever allowed once a sprint starts.

D Meet the product owner to discuss the sprint goal, and add the items to the product backlog for refinement.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader do?

A Tell the team to add them.

The PO owns the product backlog, but the developers own the sprint's work plan.

B Escalate to the sponsor.

A coaching conversation has not happened yet. Far too early.

C No changes, ever.

Too rigid. Scope can be renegotiated if it does not endanger the sprint goal.

D Meet the PO, protect the goal, route items to the backlog.

Rung 3: collaborates and coaches, and uses the backlog as the change route.

THE SIGNAL

Non-urgent new work goes to the product backlog. The sprint goal is protected by conversation, not by rules.

> Four months into a building refurbishment, the client's new head of facilities management attends a site meeting for the first time.
>
> She says the planned plant-room layout will make future maintenance difficult. She was not in the stakeholder register.

What should the project manager do?

A Explain that the design is baselined and cannot be reopened.

B Meet her to understand her concerns, then add her to the stakeholder register and plan her engagement.

C Escalate her objection to the sponsor for a decision.

D Raise a change request to redesign the plant room.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A The design is baselined.

Dismisses a stakeholder who will live with the result. Baselines can change.

B Meet her, then register and engage her.

Rungs 1 and 3: understands the concern, then brings her properly into the project.

C Escalate to the sponsor.

Nobody knows yet whether her concern is valid or what it would cost.

D Raise a change request now.

Commits to a redesign before the concern is understood. It may come later.

THE SIGNAL

A newly discovered stakeholder is engaged, not argued with or escalated. Understand before you change anything.

Understand, assess, collaborate, act, and only then **escalate**.